and were not known in political circles, but had still contested as party candidates. This problem came up more often in the case of the BSP candidates than any other party. Whether they were paying for these tickets or not, one thing was clear: the preponderance of so many rich candidates meant that the BSP was certainly not as representative of Dalits as it was purported to be. In the 2017 election, for example, it fielded more upper-caste candidates (114) than SCs (eighty-two).

Table 3.2: Percentage of Lok Sabha Candidates with >₹5 Crore Assets in UP (BJP, BSP, INC, SP), 2004–2019

Party	*2004*	*2009*	*2014*	*2019*
BJP	2.67	10.29	29.49	50.65
BSP	1.3	21.05	45	67.57
INC	4.35	15.15	37.3	50.77
SP	6.06	12.33	30.76	43.24

Percentage of Lok Sabha Candidates with >₹5 Crore Assets in India (BJP, INC), 2004–2019

Party	*2004*	*2009*	*2014*	*2019*
BJP	2.72	11.08	29.67	43.19
INC	11.3	22.25	40.8	49.64

Source: Mehta–Singh Social Index. Association for Democratic Reforms data from ECI affidavits filed by candidates, analysis by Rishabh Srivastava. Some of the increase in assets in 2019 was also due to a change in law that required candidates to additionally also declare offshore assets, and those of their spouses, children and Hindu Undivided Family.

While there is no doubt that the BSP's rise in its early years contributed to what the Dalit thinker Chandra Bhan Prasad calls a Dalit 'social revolution', these numbers empirically show why the party seemed to be 'freezing' up by 2020. It had once 'scaled Everest' in political terms, as Prasad has argued. However, as the Dalit middle-class has grown in recent years, the BSP's brand of